



US President Roosevelt and British Prime Minister Churchill meet at Casablanca in January to discuss the conduct of the war.



French Resistance fighters pose for a group portrait. The Resistance carried out acts of sabotage, gathered intelligence, and mounted guerrilla warfare operations.

IN JANUARY 1943, Franklin D. Roosevelt met British prime minister **Winston Churchill** for a conference in **Casablanca**, Morocco, which set the future course of World War II in Europe. Britain persuaded the US to **plan for an invasion of Sicily**, knowing this meant an invasion of northern France would have to be postponed until 1944. The Allied leaders also agreed that their air forces would mount a combined bomber offensive against Germany. At the end of the conference, Roosevelt announced that the Allies would **accept nothing less than the "unconditional surrender"** of their enemies.

The surrender of Axis forces at Stalingrad (see 1942) in February was a massive setback for Germany, but the Germans remained in occupation of most of Europe. In many places, **armed resistance movements** contested the occupation. A turning point for the **resistance in France** was the decision in 1943



Casablanca
The general release of the film *Casablanca* was timed to take advantage of the widely reported Casablanca Conference.

fought hard against the Germans, but were also actively hostile to the Chetnik guerrillas, led by Serb nationalist and monarchist **Draza Mihailovic**. In France, Resistance leader **Jean Moulin** strove to unite rival factions, but in May he was arrested, tortured by Gestapo chief Klaus Barbie, and died in captivity.

Spring 1943 brought the climax of the struggle against German U-boats known as the **Battle of the Atlantic**. In March, the Allies lost 285,000 tons (260,000 metric tons) of merchant shipping to German submarine attacks and there seemed a risk that Britain's lifeline of seaborne supplies would be severed. German U-boats operated in groups known as "wolf packs," coordinated by radio. But then, a combination of factors, including increased use of aircraft on ocean patrols, intelligence from decrypted German naval messages, and the equipping of convoy escorts with improved radar and radio direction-finding equipment, tilted the balance against the submarines. By May, **U-boat losses** were so high that submarine commander Admiral Karl Dönitz had to withdraw his forces from the Atlantic. The U-boat offensive never regained its momentum.

By far the heaviest land fighting of 1943 was on **Germany's eastern front**. Despite the

“ GERMANY IS A FORTRESS, BUT IT IS A FORTRESS WITHOUT A ROOF. ”

Franklin D. Roosevelt, US President, 1944

disaster at Stalingrad, Axis forces were able to mount a successful counteroffensive at **Kharkov** in the spring. This left the Soviets holding an exposed bulge of territory, or salient, at **Kursk**. German generals planned to attack from north and south to trap the Soviet forces inside the salient and destroy them. But deputy supreme commander **Georgi Zhukov** anticipated the German offensive and prepared a formidable defensive system. The forces assembled at Kursk were huge—the two sides together

totaled over 2 million men, with more than 6,000 tanks and 5,000 aircraft. The Axis onslaught began on July 5, initiating the **largest tank battle in history**. Soviet losses were heavy, but after four days the Axis offensive had stalled and the Red Army launched a counterattack. The Germans organized a fighting withdrawal but the tide of the war in the east had turned for good.

While the battle of Kursk was at its height, the Western Allies mounted a **large-scale invasion of Sicily**. US and British armies were put ashore and advanced around opposite sides of the island, receiving little opposition from Italian forces, who quickly surrendered. The campaign turned into a race between US general **George S. Patton** and British general **Bernard Montgomery**. Patton was first to reach Messina, but between them the two armies allowed most of the Axis forces to escape to mainland Italy.

The loss of Sicily was a fatal blow to the Italian dictator Benito Mussolini. After a **vote of no confidence** from the **Fascist Grand Council**, Mussolini was dismissed by King Victor Emmanuel III (1869–1947) and arrested. His replacement,



Soviet badge
This badge was awarded to Soviet tank crewmen during World War II. The Soviets lost around 5,000 tanks at Kursk in summer 1943.

JOSIP BROZ TITO (1892–1980)



Born in Croatia, Josip Broz adopted the name Tito as a communist activist in the 1930s. After the German occupation of Yugoslavia in 1941, Tito led a guerrilla movement that took control of the country in 1945. He made Yugoslavia a communist state, but resisted the dominance of the Soviet Union. He remained Yugoslav president until his death.

